

Compelling Cover Letters

This template is a guide to assist you in drafting cover letter correspondence. Your cover letter is an opportunity for you to “make your case” to a potential employer. While the prompts below are bullets, you can craft them into paragraphs using the template on the following page.

Recruiter/Contact Name

1st Paragraph – Introduce yourself and pique the company’s interest to want to learn more about you.

- Why should they read beyond the first paragraph?
- If you’ve already met, remind them where/when.
- What’s your hook? (Have you met others at the company? Do you have a unique connection?)
- Why are you interested in the company, industry, and/or function?

2nd Paragraph – Sell yourself for the position.

- Put yourself in the recruiter’s shoes – What do they want to know about you? What benefit will they realize in hiring you?
- Highlight areas of your background that would be of greatest interest to the company, but don’t simply restate your resume.
- Include something special or unique about yourself that will benefit the employer.
- If you are a career changer, this is also an opportunity to synthesize your work experience and draw parallels between your background (i.e., transferable skills) and the position you’re seeking.

3rd Paragraph – Reconfirm your interest and thank them for their consideration.

- Reconfirm your interest in a way that is not redundant.
- Reinforce why you think it would be a good cultural fit. (Do you share similar values, for example?)
- Finally, ask for an invitation to interview and thank them for their consideration. Outline possible next steps if appropriate.

Cover Letter Correspondence – Template

First and Last Name
Street Address
City, State, Zip Code
Email Address | Phone Number

Date

Recruiter/Contact Name
Title
Company
Street Address
City, State, Zip Code

Re: <Position Name/Job Posting # if available>

Dear <Mr./Ms. LastName>, *(Always make an extra effort to locate a company contact if none is listed; if you do not have a contact name, “Dear Hiring Manager” is preferable to “To Whom It May Concern.”)*

Opening Paragraph – Explain why you are writing by referring to a specific position, field of interest, or who or what led you to this organization/individual. Explain why *this* position at *this* firm is compelling to you. Pique your reader’s interest by describing how you may contribute to this organization and any related training or experience that makes you uniquely qualified.

Middle Paragraph/s – Use the middle one to two paragraphs to create interest in learning more about you. Mention two or three qualifications that display your strengths relative to the position you seek. Clearly convey how your background has prepared you to contribute to the firm’s objectives.

Final Paragraph – Close by reconfirming your interest. Mention why you think it would be a good fit on both sides. Indicate that you’d appreciate an opportunity to interview, and thank them for their consideration. Outline next possible steps if appropriate.

Sincerely,

Name

Resources:

Online:

- Alumni = Career Services > Changing Companies, Functions, and Industries > Resumes and Cover Letters
- E/W = Careers > Market & Prepare Yourself > Write a Cover Letter

Books:

- *Best Cover Letters for \$100,000 + Jobs* – Wendy S. Enelow
- *201 Winning Cover Letters for \$100,000 Jobs* – Wendy S. Enelow
- *175 High Impact Cover Letters* – Richard H. Beatty

General Resources:

- Book a career coaching appointment via GTS or boothworks@ChicagoBooth.edu or 312-464-8677